

NEIVA J. FORTES

570-904-3971 | njfortes@syr.edu | Department of Economics, Syracuse University, Syracuse, NY 13244

EDUCATION

Syracuse University

2022–Present

Ph.D. in Economics, expected May 2027

Dissertation: Essays in the Economics of Education and Health

Dissertation Committee: Monica Deza (Chair), John Cawley, Maria Zhu, and Ying Shi

Hartwick College

2018–2022

B.A. in Mathematics and Economics, summa cum laude

RESEARCH FIELDS

Economics of Education, Health Economics, Labor Economics, Economics of Crime

WORKING PAPERS

“The Effects of State-Mandated Elementary School Recess Laws on Discriminatory Bullying” (*Job Market Paper*)

Recess has long been part of elementary school curricula, yet historically lacked legal protection, allowing schools to restrict access in ways that disproportionately affected minority and low-income students. In 2016, Rhode Island mandated recess statewide. Using nationwide school-level administrative data and synthetic control methods, I estimate the effect of this mandate on discriminatory bullying allegations. By 2018, sex-based bullying allegations increased by an estimated 182 statewide relative to the synthetic control counterfactual, while race- and disability-based allegations were unchanged. The increase is concentrated in high-poverty and high-minority schools, where estimates are roughly five to seven times larger than in their counterparts. The findings are consistent with either increased detection under greater adult supervision or greater exposure to bullying opportunities during unstructured peer interaction.

“The Effect of Height on Adolescents’ Body Image Perceptions and Behaviors”

with Monica Deza and Maria Zhu

NBER Working Paper No. 35293, June 2026. DOI: 10.3386/w35293. [NBER page](#)

This paper estimates the causal effect of height on adolescents’ body image, encompassing self-perceptions of weight, the accuracy of those perceptions, and weight-management aspirations. Using data from the National Longitudinal Survey of Youth 1997 (NLSY97), we leverage within-individual variation in height during adolescence and condition on body mass index (BMI) to isolate the effects of height on body image outcomes. We find that taller adolescents are more likely to perceive themselves as overweight, even holding BMI constant, and are less likely to underestimate their weight category. However, the direction of misclassification diverges by gender: taller boys are more likely to correctly assess their weight category, while taller girls are more likely to overestimate it. These perception shifts translate into behavioral responses for girls but not for boys. A one-inch increase in height raises the probability that a girl reports wanting to lose weight by 3.0 percentage points (6.2 percent), with effects concentrated among girls in the normal weight range. Taken together, these findings establish height as a salient determinant of body image in adolescence, operating independently of body mass.

WORK IN PROGRESS

“Sibling Spillover Effects of Chronic Illness on Educational and Labor Market Outcomes”

This paper examines how the onset of a sibling’s chronic health condition affects the behavioral, academic, and long-run outcomes of children without chronic conditions. Using longitudinal data from the Panel Study of Income Dynamics–Child Development Supplement, I employ a within-child fixed-effects design that compares the same child before and after a sibling develops a chronic condition. I find little evidence of broad behavioral harm on average, but meaningful heterogeneity emerges. Siblings exhibit improved emotional regulation, including reductions in stubbornness and anxiety, alongside a modest increase in peer-relationship difficulties. These effects are concentrated primarily among girls in higher-income households, a pattern consistent with adaptive parentification supported by greater family resources. A planned extension will use sibling and genome-wide data from the National Longitudinal Study of Adolescent to Adult Health. By using a sibling’s polygenic risk for chronic illness as an instrument for illness onset, the analysis aims to strengthen causal identification, examine mechanisms such as

parental time allocation and peer-network formation, and determine whether spillover effects persist into adulthood.

“Standing Out and Bullying: Relative Height, BMI, and Adolescent Bullying Victimization”

This paper examines whether adolescents’ physical characteristics relative to their peer group, rather than in absolute terms, predict bullying victimization at school. Using Youth Risk Behavior Surveillance System (YRBSS) district-level data from 2009 to 2021, I construct peer-relative measures of height and BMI within school district, grade, year, and sex cells, and estimate their association with self-reported bullying victimization using a linear probability model with district and grade-specific time trends. I find that being taller than one’s peer group is protective for boys but a risk factor for girls, while being heavier than peers is associated with higher bullying risk for both sexes, with a penalty nearly three times larger for girls. Heterogeneity analysis by weight category reveals that this weight penalty reverses among underweight students and compounds among already-overweight students, suggesting that the relevant mechanism is distance from the perceived peer norm rather than absolute body size.

“The Effects of High School Students’ Class Choices on College Outcomes”

This paper investigates whether the rigor of high school coursework, specifically, enrollment in Advanced Placement and honors courses relative to general academic tracks, affects the selectivity of the four-year colleges students attend. While prior research establishes a relationship between advanced coursework and the extensive margin of college enrollment, evidence on whether such coursework improves access to more selective institutions remains limited. Using the High School Longitudinal Study of 2009 (HSLS:09), a nationally representative cohort followed from ninth grade through postsecondary entry, the planned analysis will address the endogeneity of course selection using instrumental variables and regression discontinuity designs. The instrumental-variables approach will leverage variation in school-level access to advanced courses, while the regression-discontinuity design will exploit GPA-based eligibility thresholds for enrollment in these courses. By separating curricular rigor from underlying academic ability and family background, the study aims to estimate its effect on postsecondary selectivity and contribute to the literature on human capital signaling and college match.

CONFERENCE AND INVITED PRESENTATIONS

** Scheduled*

Southern Economic Association 96th Annual Meeting, Houston, TX	Nov. 2026*
“The Effects of State-Mandated Elementary School Recess Laws on Discriminatory Bullying”	
APPAM Annual Fall Research Conference	Nov. 2026*
“The Effects of State-Mandated Elementary School Recess Laws on Discriminatory Bullying” (poster)	
FLX Economics of Education Workshop, Syracuse, NY	May 2026
“The Effects of State-Mandated Elementary School Recess Laws on Discriminatory Bullying”	
Center for Policy Research Poster Reception, Syracuse University	2026
“The Effects of State-Mandated Elementary School Recess Laws on Discriminatory Bullying”	
Center for Policy Research Poster Reception, Syracuse University	2025
“The Effects of State-Mandated Recess Laws on Youth Crime”	
Invited Seminar, Hartwick College, Oneonta, NY	2025
“The Effects of State-Mandated Elementary School Recess Laws on Discriminatory Bullying”	

AWARDS, FELLOWSHIPS, AND HONORS

NIA T32 Predoctoral Fellowship, Syracuse University	2026–Present
Selected Participant, NBER Summer Institute – Economics of Crime, Cambridge, MA	July 2026
Chicago Price Theory Summer Camp, University of Chicago	June 2026
Roscoe Martin Fund for Dissertation and Thesis Research	2025–2026
Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award, Syracuse University	2023–2024
McNair Fellowship, Syracuse University	2022–2023
John Christopher Hartwick Scholarship, Hartwick College	2021–2022
Robert E. Newnham ’50, H’96 Mathematics Scholarship, Hartwick College	2021–2022
Faculty Scholar, Hartwick College	2021–2022
Andrew B. Saxton Fellowship in Economics and Mathematics, Hartwick College	2020–2022

Hartwick College Honors Program	2020–2022
Kappa Mu Epsilon	2020–2022
National Society of Leadership and Success	2018–2022

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Assistant, Center for Policy Research, Syracuse University	2026–Present
NIA T32 Predoctoral Training Program in Policy, Place, Population Health, and Aging (P3HA) Trainee	
<i>Faculty supervisor: John Cawley</i>	
Graduate Research Assistant, Department of Economics, Syracuse University	2025–2026
<i>Faculty supervisor: John Cawley</i>	
Graduate Research Assistant, Department of Economics, Syracuse University	2024–2025
<i>Faculty supervisors: Monica Deza and Yulya Truskinovsky</i>	

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record, Principles of Microeconomics (ECN 101), Syracuse University	Summers 2024–2026
<i>Enrollment: 12 students (2024), 22 students (2025), and 6 students (2026)</i>	
Teaching Assistant, Intermediate Microeconomics (ECN 301), Syracuse University	2023–2024
<i>Enrollment: Approximately 50-60 students</i>	
Teaching Assistant, Diversity and Democracy, Hartwick College	Jan. 2022
<i>Enrollment: Approximately 15–20 students</i>	

ADDITIONAL PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Assistant Director of Admissions, Hartwick College	Jan. 2022
Small Business Coordinator, National Development Council	2021–2022

LANGUAGES

English (fluent) | Cape Verdean Creole (fluent) | Portuguese (fluent) | Spanish (intermediate)

REFERENCES

Monica Deza (Chair), Syracuse University	mdeza@syr.edu
John Cawley, Syracuse University	jhcawley@syr.edu
Maria Zhu, Syracuse University	mzhu33@syr.edu
Ying Shi, Syracuse University	yshi78@syr.edu